PERKALATE / RETAIL

The Second Visit Playbook for Physical Stores

How shops and chains turn first time walk ins into regulars: what to hand over at the counter, when to invite them back, and how to track it.

A first visit is often luck: a walk by, a friend's recommendation, a rainy afternoon. A second visit is a decision. Once a customer has come back on purpose, they're on their way to becoming a regular.

This playbook is about making that second visit more likely, for single location shops and chains alike.

Step 1: Know your first time visitors

You can't bring back people you can't tell apart. A few simple ways to spot them:

- Ask at the register: "First time in?" It's friendly and gives you a count.
- Track new payment cards, if your point of sale shows that.
- Note how many people sign up for anything at the counter each week.

Even a rough tally gives you a baseline to improve on.

Step 2: Give them a reason before they leave

The best moment to plant a second visit is during the first one. Before a new customer leaves, they should have something that points them back:

- A reward valid on their next visit, not today.
- A reason tied to timing: a restock day, a tasting, a workshop, a seasonal drop.
- Something they can keep on their phone, not a paper slip that ends up in a coat pocket.

Make the offer specific to a future visit so it can't simply become a discount on today's purchase.

Step 3: Point them at your quiet hours

If the reward is good any time, most people will use it when they'd shop anyway. If it's good during your slower hours, you get the second visit and you fill a gap in your day. Be clear about the window and make it easy to remember. "Weekday afternoons" beats a list of exact times.

Step 4: Train the counter

Staff make or break this. Give them one sentence they can say naturally, such as "Come back on a weekday afternoon and there's a little something waiting for you," and show them exactly how a customer claims it. If claiming takes more than a few seconds at a busy register, people won't bother.

Step 5: Treat regulars differently

Regulars don't need a discount to return, and giving them one cuts margin without changing what they do. Thank them in ways that feel personal instead: early access to new stock, a heads up before a sale, being recognized by name. Save funded rewards for the people who need a reason.

Step 6: Borrow customers from your neighbors

Some of your best future regulars already shop nearby. Someone loyal to the coffee shop down the street or the gym on the corner is already in your area at predictable times. Partnering with nearby businesses, or reaching their loyal customers directly, can bring in first visits that are far more likely to turn into second ones.

Step 7: Check results every two weeks

Count how many rewards went out, how many were claimed and how many were used. Compare redemption hours against your slow blocks. Change one thing at a time so you know what made the difference.

Plan a pilot

Choose one audience, one reward and one result to measure. Set the budget and eligibility rules before launch. Tell participants which information you need and share results in aggregate where possible.